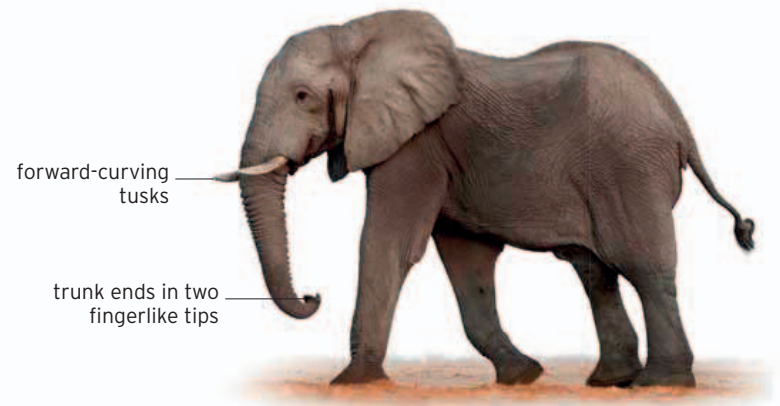




African savanna elephant

Loxodonta africana

The world's largest land animal, African savanna elephants are capable of carving paths through dense undergrowth, clearing shrubs, and excavating waterholes. They also help to replant forests because they excrete the seeds of fruit that they eat—many species of tree depend on African elephants for survival.

The elephant's range is shrinking rapidly due to expanding human population. As many as 3–5 million elephants roamed Africa less than a century ago, but today an estimated 470,000–690,000 are confined to fragmented areas south of the Sahara. More elephants die annually from hunting and ivory poaching than are born.

Complex anatomy

The African elephant's head weighs up to half a ton and its brain is larger than any other land animal's—about four times the size of the human brain. Its trunk—a fusion between upper lip and nose—contains a staggering 40,000 muscle bundles. The trunk is so adaptable that the elephant can pluck a grape-sized fruit without damaging it or throw a 12-in- (30-cm-) thick tree limb. Besides breathing, the elephant uses its trunk to smell, touch, and caress its family members, as well as to feed and drink. Its enormous ears are full of blood

Elephants care for and aid wounded relatives

vessels that radiate excess heat, while its tusks are used for tearing the bark and limbs of trees as well as for defense. Both male and female African elephants have tusks, although the female's tusks are shorter.

Females rule elephant society, which is highly social and family-based, with a matriarch leading related females and calves. The young are dependent on their mother for 8–10 years, learning how to behave, where to find water, and what to eat. Females remain with their birth herd, while most males leave at around 14 years old, joining other bulls in loose-knit bachelor herds and only coming into contact with females to mate.

Elephants are highly vocal communicators, with calls ranging from high-pitched squeaks to low-frequency “infrasound” rumbles. The deep rumbles can travel more than 2 miles (3km) in the air and three times that distance through the ground, and elephants detect these vibrations through their feet and trunk.

▷ REFRESHING SHOWER

Bathing after drinking is a common activity. Elephants frequently use their trunks to spray themselves and each other with water.

◁ MIGHTY TUSKER

A fully grown bull African elephant with enormous tusks is a formidable opponent, capable of charges up to 25 mph (40 km/h).



- ↔ 13–16½ ft (4–5 m)
- ⚖ 4–7 tons
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🌿 Grass, fruit, flowers
- 🏠 🌳 🌳 🌳 🌳

